

CHAPTER 39

EXPRESSIVITY AND GESTURES

CORNELIA EBERT AND SEBASTIAN WALTER

39.1 INTRODUCTION

Gestures, as integral components of human communication, serve as powerful tools for conveying emotions, thoughts, and intentions (McNeill 1992, Kendon 2004). They have frequently been argued to offer a unique window into the speaker's mind, revealing their feelings or even unconscious thoughts as well as aspects of meaning that spoken language alone might not fully capture¹. Most explicitly, this has been put forth in various publications by researchers such as David McNeill (2013) and Susan Goldin-Meadow (2005). Likewise, expressives as spoken language items have been argued to contribute meaning that sheds light on the speaker's emotional state. Potts (2012: 2532) writes that they create "a window into [the speaker's] underlying emotional state at the time of utterance" and that they encode "charged information about the speaker's emotional state" (Potts 2012: 2517).

Expressives are a class of linguistic elements that include items such as interjections like *ouch*, epithets like *bastard* (as in (1)), and certain adjectives that convey the speaker's

¹ This observation also generalizes to sign languages (e.g., Emmorey 1999, Goldin-Meadow & Brentari 2017). Due to reasons of space, we limit our attention to the relation between gesture and spoken language in this contribution.

attitudes and emotions such as *damn* (see (2)) as well as so-called mixed items as *cur* (3) (↪ *Expressivity: an introduction* by DANIEL GUTZMANN AND KATHARINA TURGAY, Chapter 1 of this volume). *Being very extraordinary spoken language expressions*, they have often been that have often been analyzed as direct pointers to the speaker's mind that reflect the speaker's emotions in language in a very direct way and indicate that the speaker is in a "heightened emotional state" Potts (2007: 171).

- (1) I hear your damn dog barking all night. (Potts 2005: 18)
- (2) That bastard Kresge is famous. (Potts 2007: 168)
- (3) This cur howled the whole night. (Gutzmann 2012: 23)

Gestures are often defined as communicative movements of the hands, arms, and sometimes the face, which accompany speech and add layers of meaning to an utterance. Far from being mere supplementary actions, gestures and speech are deeply intertwined, working together to create a richer, more nuanced form of communication. Scholars like McNeill (1992, 2005), de Ruiter (1998, 2000, 2007), and Kendon (2004) have long emphasized the symbiotic relationship between gesture and speech, arguing that gestures contribute meaning in a way that is temporally aligned with and dependent on the spoken word. This alignment is not arbitrary; different patterns of gesture-speech synchronization can lead to different interpretations of the gesture, highlighting the complex interaction between these two modes of communication.

In recent years, there has been growing interest in understanding the semantic contributions of gestures within formal linguistics, particularly in how they interact with the spoken component of an utterance. Research has shown that gestures often convey what is known as not-at-issue content – information that is present in the communication but does not belong to the main assertion of an utterance and does not directly influence the truth conditions (Potts 2005). This characteristic is shared with expressives. Expressives are special in that they operate in a different dimension of meaning from the propositional content of an utterance. For example, in (2) the word *bastard* conveys the speaker's negative attitude toward Kresge independently of the truth of the proposition that Kresge is famous.

This contribution seeks to explore the intersection of expressivity and gestures, investigating how different types of gestures that will be introduced and discussed in Section 39.2 vary in their degree of conventionalization and lexicalization. It will be examined how these different types of gestures function within communication, with a particular focus on how they align with or diverge from the properties of expressives as outlined by Potts (2007) (presented in Section 39.4). By drawing comparisons between gestures and expressives, this study aims at providing a deeper understanding of the role gestures play in conveying meaning beyond the spoken word and to better grasp the concept of expressivity including all modalities. Hereby, we aim at contributing to the ongoing discourse on the semantic and pragmatic roles of gestures in communication challenging the traditional boundaries between verbal and non-verbal communication. We propose that gestures, like expressives, occupy a unique space in the linguistic landscape. Moreover, by extending the theoretical framework of expressives to include gestures, this study opens new avenues for understanding the full spectrum of human communicative behavior.

As we will argue, there is one specific type of gesture, namely *emblematic gestures* like showing the middle finger or the thumbs-up gesture, for example, whose representatives are highly conventionalized within a certain cultural community and behave very much like spoken language expressive items in many significant ways. Both, expressives and emblems, often convey not-at-issue content, and can operate independently of the accompanying speech. Emblematic gestures, much like expressives, are deeply rooted in cultural conventions and are capable of expressing entire speech acts by themselves. And most significantly, both express the speaker's emotions in a very direct and unfiltered way.

This chapter is structured as follows: Section 39.2 will provide an overview of gesture semantics, focusing on different kinds of gestures including emblematic gestures, as well as their respective roles in communication. Section 39.3 is concerned with the concept of not-at-issueness and will examine the at-issue status of different gesture types. Section 39.4 lays out the characteristics of expressivity that have been proposed by (Potts 2007) and demonstrates how different gesture types align with these characteristics. In this section, we will furthermore discuss the implications of these findings for our understanding of gesture in communication, arguing that emblematic gestures should be considered alongside expressives as a distinct class of communicative acts. Finally, Section 39.5 will offer conclusions and suggestions for future research, highlighting the need for further exploration into the nuanced roles of gestures in human communication.

39.2 GESTURE

.....

Gestures are defined as communicative movements of the hands and arms and also facial expressions which transport emotions, thoughts, and intentions. This means that they add meaning to an utterance. More specifically, gesture and speech contribute to the meaning of an utterance together (e.g., McNeill 1992, de Ruiter 1998, Kendon 2004, Ebert 2024). Gesture and speech are temporally aligned (McNeill 1992, Loehr 2004, Ebert, Evert & Wilmes 2011) and different gesture-speech alignment patterns result in different interpretations of the gesture (McNeill 1992, Ebert, Pirillo & Walter 2022). The latter can be verified by considering the example in (4). We use small caps to indicate a speech-accompanying gesture and underlining to indicate gesture-speech alignment.

(4) There is a window in my living room. + ROUND

The indefinite DP *a window* is aligned with an *iconic* gesture providing information about the shape of the window in the speaker's living room. An iconic gesture is a gesture that depicts a certain property of an object or an event by mapping it to the gesture space. Note that timing is meaningful here and the utterance would appear deviant if the ROUND gesture were aligned with the speech expression *my living room*.

Following Schlenker's (2018) terminology, we call an instance of a speech-accompanying gesture that co-occurs with the speech signal a *co-speech gesture* (4). Other possible alignment patterns of gesture and speech are *pro-speech gestures* (5) and *post-speech gestures* (6).

- (5) The window in my living room is _____. + ROUND
 (6) Last year we went to Greece. _____ + HIKING (Ebert 2024: 171)

Pro-speech gestures are gestures that replace speech, post-speech gestures occur after the speech signal. Speech-accompanying gestures can also occur *pre-speech*. However, as this alignment pattern is not of relevance for the realm of this contribution, it will not be discussed here. These alignment patterns – co-, post-, pre- and pro-speech – are not tied to iconic gestures as one specific type of gesture, but can be found with all gesture types. As with iconic gestures, we hence also find these different alignment sites with another type of gesture, namely *pointing gestures*. In Western European communities, pointing gestures are often performed with a stretched index finger to point to an object or to place an imaginary referent in the gesture space. Other communities use their nose or the shoulder to point.

- (7) There is a window in my living room. + POINTING TO WINDOW
 (8) My living room has a very big _____. + POINTING TO WINDOW
 (9) There is a window in my living room. _____ + POINTING TO WINDOW

The different alignment patterns of gesture and speech show that gesture and speech systematically contribute meaning to the overall utterance. Different alignment sites (e.g., co- vs. post-) lead to different interpretations and different types of gestures (e.g., iconic vs. pointing) also make different meaning contributions.

One can note from looking at the examples in (4)-(6) that iconic gestures seem to have a relatively underspecified meaning that is strongly dependent on the verbal context that the gesture co-occurs in. For example, in (4) and (5), the gesture contributes meaning about the shape of the window in the speaker's living room. Without the speech signal, however, the exact meaning contribution of the iconic gesture is highly underspecified. The gesture only becomes interpretable when taking into account the verbal context it co-occurs in (McNeill 1992). It has therefore been proposed that iconic gestures (and pointing gestures) depend on a so-called constructional meaning, i.e., beside their highly underspecified core meaning contribution, they depend on the co-occurring speech signal as well as their alignment pattern (Ebert, Ebert & Hörnig 2020).

Iconic gestures thus typically exhibit a low degree of *conventionalization*. This is further strengthened by the observation that speakers normally have several options to gesturally depict something by means of an iconic gesture. In (4) and (5), speakers can for example choose to use both their hands or only one hand when producing the ROUND-gesture. On a conventionalization scale for speech-accompanying gestures, iconic gestures would thus mark the low end of this scale.

Turning now to another type of speech-accompanying gesture that we already briefly touched upon above, *emblematic gestures*, we will see that they stand in sharp contrast to iconic gestures in terms of their degree of conventionalization. They have been argued to be instances of lexicalized gestures within a language community (e.g., Kendon 1988). This means that this type of gesture has a fixed meaning, which does not depend on the speech signal it (potentially) co-occurs with in a similar way as iconic gestures do.

- (10) A: Have you already eaten?
B: THUMBS UP

This example shows that this type of gesture can stand alone and it seems to be able to transport an entire speech act of its own. In this case it means affirmation plus some additional meaning component of positive affection with a content somewhat along the lines of *I liked it*. Further examples of emblematic gestures include the victory sign or the artichoke, predominantly used and highly conventionalized in Italian communities (Kendon 2004, Ippolito 2021, Steinbach, Coniglio & Paul 2023).

Although it has been noted that emblematic gestures, possibly due to their ability to perform entire speech acts and/or their high degree of conventionalization, often occur as pro-speech gestures, as shown in (10); co-speech (11) or post-speech (12) occurrence is also possible:

- (11) I went to the cinema yesterday. + THUMBS UP
(12) I went to the cinema yesterday. _____ + THUMBS UP

We will elaborate on the differences the different alignment patterns make for iconic and emblematic gestures in Section 39.3.2. As in the case of the pro-speech example (10) above, the gesture in (11) and (12) seems to add an expressive speech act of *I enjoyed it*, which, in these examples, is additional to the proposition that is expressed in speech. As we will see, this sets emblems in general apart from iconic gestures because their meaning contribution is seemingly not as closely tied to the proposition expressed by the speech signal. In other words, emblems can be used to express entire speech acts, which is less easily possible with iconic gestures because their interpretation depends more closely on the co-occurring speech signal.

Before turning to the semantic contributions iconic and emblematic gestures make, we would like to point out that there is a further subclass of iconic gestures whose expressive potential will also be discussed in Section 39.4: so-called *viewpoint gestures*. It has first been noted by McNeill (1992) that not only spoken and signed utterances, but also speech-accompanying gestures can encode perspective, i.e., viewpoint. The main distinction to be drawn here is the one between so-called *character* and *observer viewpoint gestures* (henceforth CVGs and OVGs, respectively). A CVG encodes an internal first-person perspective. Consequently, the whole body is normally involved in the production of a CVG. By contrast, OVGs depict an event as if observed from a distance. Thus, when producing an OVG, the speaker adopts a more external, third-person point of view where only hands and arms are involved in the gesture production. We will refer to gestures that do not encode a certain viewpoint as *no viewpoint gestures*, henceforth NoVGs.

As for viewpoint gestures, we already encountered an example in (6), an alternative where the gesture occurs co-speech is given in (13):

- (13) Last year we went to Greece. + HIKING

The HIKING-gesture in (13) (and (6)) can either be performed as a CVG where the speaker uses their whole body to depict the hiking event referred to in the speech signal or as an



(A) A skunk hopping across a room. Parrill (Cartoon scene from 2010: 651)



(B) CVG used to depict the skunk in Figure 39.1a (Figure 3 in Parrill 2010: 652)



(C) OVG used to depict the skunk in Figure 39.1a (Figure 2 in Parrill 2010: 651)

FIGURE 39.1 – Examples for a CVG and an OVG to depict the same event

OVG where the speaker uses their index and middle finger to represent the legs of a person hiking. In addition, they could, for example, move their gesturing hand from the down right corner of the gesture space diagonally upward toward the upper left corner to additionally show that the hiking involved some sort of elevation.

A further example of a CVG is given in Figure 39.1(B) and one for an OVG in 39.1(C). Both describe the event shown in Figure 39.1(A). Figure 39.1(A) stems from a study reported in Parrill (2010) where participants had to describe cartoon clips to a friend they brought to the study. The study aimed at investigating differences between CVGs and OVGs. Previous research has already shown that CVGs occur more frequently with transitive utterances than OVGs (McNeill 1992), a finding that was replicated by Parrill (2010). Moreover, Parrill (2010) noted that there are different preferences for which information the two types of viewpoint gestures typically encode: CVGs can encode affect, for example, OVGs tend to encode trajectories. This is illustrated by the gestures in Figure 39.1. Moreover, CVGs have been shown to be more informative than OVGs (Beattie & Shovelton 2002). Preferences to adopt a certain gestural viewpoint are also language-specific as they depend on which event structures are typically lexically encoded (Özyürek et al. 2005, Stec 2012). These preferences are so strong that already intermediate L2 learners adopt the gestural viewpoint preference of a language (Brown 2008).

39.3 (NOT-)AT-ISSUENESS IN SPEECH AND GESTURE

.....

39.3.1 (Not-)at-issueness in speech

Since the pioneering work by Kaplan (1999/2004), expressives have received substantial attention in formal semantic and pragmatic research (Potts 2005, 2007, Gutzmann 2012, Rett 2021, among many others). Kaplan (1999/2004) investigated expressions such as epithets (2), repeated here as (14)), interjections, ethnic slur terms, greetings (15), and expressive adjectives (16).

(14) That bastard Kresge is famous.

(15) Hello.

(16) Where did I put my damn wallet?

Kaplan (1999/2004) notes that these expressives cannot be analyzed in terms of truth conditions and that, instead, they have to be analyzed as depending on so-called *use conditions* (↔ *Expressivity and multidimensional semantics* by DANIEL GUTZMANN, Chapter 11 of this volume). It is hard – if not impossible – to define when the greeting in (15) is true and it seems much more plausible to define conditions under which (15) can be felicitously uttered instead, i.e., its use conditions (Gutzmann 2012). This is what led Potts (2005) (and later Potts 2007) to propose that expressive content needs to be handled in a different dimension of meaning, the not-at-issue dimension.² Going even further, experimental research on expressives suggests that they are also independent on the level of pragmatics as the utterance of an expressive results in the performance of an additional speech act which is expressive (Frazier, Dillon & Clifton 2015, 2018).

Furthermore, as has been pointed out above, for expressives like *bastard* in (14), the expressive component that the speaker dislikes Kresge is independent of the truth conditions of the sentence, which are fulfilled if Kresge is indeed famous. That the speaker has negative affection towards Kresge is not-at-issue and information that is handled in a different dimension. In the following, we will elaborate on the concept of not-at-issueness as a separate dimension of meaning a little bit further.

When uttering a sentence, speakers sometimes express multiple propositions. However, some propositions in a conversation are not as relevant to the overall discourse topic as others. Following Simons, Tonhauser, Beaver & Roberts (2010), the at-issue part of an utterance can be defined as those propositions that address the current *question under discussion* (QUD, henceforth). Not-at-issue propositions, by contrast, are those the speaker does not intend to steer the conversation toward. As mentioned before, expressives are arguably to be interpreted in the not-at-issue dimension. Next to expressives, also appositives are well-known examples of not-at-issue content in the spoken modality (e.g., Potts 2005). Consider the following example containing an appositive:

² However, note that in Potts 2005, expressives nevertheless receive a truth-conditional treatment.

- (17) My friend Sophie, a classical violinist, performed a piece by Mozart. (Syrett & Koev 2015: 525)

When uttering the sentence in (17), at least two propositions are expressed: i) the speaker's friend Sophie performed a piece by Mozart and ii) Sophie is a classical violinist. The first, i.e., the proposition expressed by the main clause is the at-issue proposition as it can be used to address a QUD:

- (18) Q: What did Sophie do?
Sophie, a classical violinist, performed a piece by Mozart.

Interestingly, however, when posing an overt QUD addressing the appositive's content, the utterance in (17) seems to be an infelicitous answer to that question.

- (19) Q: What is Sophie's profession?
#Sophie, a classical violinist, performed a piece by Mozart.

Therefore, in the default case, an appositive's content cannot address the QUD and is not-at-issue (but see AnderBois, Brasoveanu & Henderson 2015 and Koev 2018 for examples of appositives addressing the QUD and thus making an at-issue contribution). Consequently, not-at-issue content has been argued to be not on the table for discussion (Farkas & Bruce 2010). Other accounts argue that while not-at-issue content is silently imposed on the common ground, speakers use at-issue content to propose a common ground update (AnderBois, Brasoveanu & Henderson 2015).

At-issue and not-at-issue propositions differ in significant ways in their discourse behavior, which has lead to a variety of tools to diagnose (not-)at-issue content (e.g., Tonhauser 2012, ↪ *Expressivity: an introduction* by DANIEL GUTZMANN AND KATHARINA TURGAY, Chapter 1 of this volume). In the following, we will discuss three such diagnostics for not-at-issue content: the projection test, the direct denial test, and the ellipsis test.

Not-at-issue content in general projects (e.g., Beaver, Roberts, Simons & Tonhauser 2017), meaning that it cannot be targeted by semantic operators such as negation. Going even further, there is research building on Simons, Tonhauser, Beaver & Roberts (2010) suggesting that content projects only to the extent that it is not-at-issue (Tonhauser, Beaver & Degen 2018), which implies that at-issueness is also gradient (cf. Barnes, Ebert, Hörnig & Stender 2022, Barnes & Ebert 2023b). For illustration, verify that if (17) is embedded under a sentential negation only the main clause is targeted, but not the proposition expressed by the appositive:

- (20) It is not the case that my friend Sophie, a classical violinist, performed a piece by Mozart.

The sentence in the above example can only be interpreted as stating that it is not the case that Sophie performed a piece by Mozart. The intuition that the speaker believes that Sophie is a classical violinist, that is, the appositive proposition, remains untouched by the negative operator. As a consequence, only the continuation in (21) is felicitous, but not the continuation in (22).

(21) She performed a piece by Bach.

(22) #She plays the trumpet.

Furthermore, not-at-issue content cannot be directly assented or dissented with in discourse (cf. (23)).

(23) A: My friend Sophie, a classical violinist, performed a piece by Mozart.

B₁: #No, she does not play the violin. She plays the trumpet!

Instead, to target the proposition expressed by the appositive, a *discourse-interrupting element* needs to be used (von Fintel 2004, building on Shanon 1976) to felicitously deny the appositive proposition.

(24) B₂: Hey, wait a minute! She doesn't play the violin, she plays the trumpet.

This test has originally been employed to test for presuppositions exclusively, but has later been expanded to test for not-at-issue content in general (Pearson 2010, Potts 2012, but see Syrett & Koev 2015 for a critical discussion).

Alternatively, to target the appositive proposition, one can use an adversative continuation following an affirmation. The adversative continuation is only felicitous if it carries not-at-issue content (cf. diagnostic #1c for (not-)at-issue content in Tonhauser 2012).

(25) A: My friend Sophie, a classical violinist, performed a piece by Mozart.

B₃: Yes, she did, but she is actually not a classical violinist. She plays the trumpet.

The final property of not-at-issue content that will be used as a diagnostic in this contribution is that it can be neglected under ellipsis (see McCawley 1998 and Potts 2005, who discuss this property for appositives and Potts et al. 2009 for expressives).

(26) A: I met Jordan, the greatest yoga instructor of all time, at the Italian restaurant yesterday.

B: Last Monday, I did, too. But I actually don't think he's the greatest yoga instructor of all time.

In (26), B first agrees with A's utterance. Only later they clarify that they disagree with the proposition A expressed in the appositive that Jordan is the best yoga instructor of all time, showing that B initially disregards the appositive's content in the ellipsis construction.

Summing up, not-at-issue content in general does not address the QUD. Moreover, it cannot be directly denied in discourse, it escapes the scope of negation and other semantic operators, and finally, it can be disregarded under ellipsis.

39.3.2 (Not-)at-issueness in speech-accompanying gestures

In recent semantic literature, it has been argued that co-speech gestures transmit not-at-issue information by default (Ebert & Ebert 2014, Ebert, Ebert & Hörnig 2020, Schlenker 2018, but see Esipova 2019a). To argue for the not-at-issueness of gestures, most accounts

of speech-accompanying gestures deal with iconic gestures. However, the account by Ebert, Ebert & Hörnig (2020) also makes predictions about pointing gestures and Esipova (2019b) investigates, among other things, the semantic contribution of emblematic gestures. This section will elaborate on the at-issue status of different types of speech-accompanying gestures.

39.3.2.1 (Not-)at-issueness of iconic gestures

Recent formal semantic literature that deals with gesture semantics is predominantly concerned with iconic co-speech gestures (Lascarides & Stone 2009, Schlenker 2018, Esipova 2019a, Ebert, Ebert & Hörnig 2020). That is, there is more research on the at-issue status of iconic gestures in comparison to emblematic gestures, and most of this research is on co-speech gestures and very little on post- or pro-speech gestures. We will therefore start with looking at the at-issue status of iconic gestures (first at NoVGs, then at CVGs and OVGs) in the different alignment patterns relevant for the endeavor of the present work and then turn to emblematic gestures.

Iconic co-speech gestures have been argued to contribute not-at-issue meaning by default (Schlenker 2018, Ebert, Ebert & Hörnig 2020). Thus, co-speech NoVGs, CVGs, and OVGs should pattern with appositives in the tests described above. Starting with projectivity, they clearly do.

- (27) It is not the case that there is a window in my living room. + RECTANGULAR
#It is actually round.
- (28) It is not the case that we went to Greece last year. + CVG/OVG HIKING
#We went there to go to the beach.

The continuations of (27) and (28) are infelicitous as they contradict the gesture's content, which projected out of the negation.

In addition, all three types of iconic co-speech gestures cannot be directly denied in discourse:

- (29) A: There is a window in my living room. + RECTANGULAR
B₁: #No, the window is round.
B₂: Hey, wait a minute! The window is actually round.
- (30) A: We went to Greece last year. + CVG/OVG HIKING
B₁: #No, you did not go hiking there.
B₂: Hey, wait a minute! You actually didn't go on any hikes there.

Again, all three types of iconic co-speech gestures pattern with appositives, suggesting that they contribute not-at-issue meaning by default.

Finally, they can be neglected in ellipsis constructions (cf. Schlenker & Chemla 2018, Ebert, Konietzko & Weskott 2021):

- (31) A: There is a window in my living room. + RECTANGULAR
B: In mine, too. But mine is actually round.

- (32) A: We went to Greece last year. + CVG/OVG HIKING
 B: Two years ago, I did, too! But I actually didn't go on any hikes there.

The data clearly support the view that iconic co-speech gestures contribute not-at-issue meaning by default. Additionally, there is experimental support for the not-at-issueness of NoVGs (Ebert, Ebert & Hörnig 2020) and CVGs and OVGs (Walter 2024). Interestingly, however, CVGs seem to be able to shift more toward the at-issue dimension than OVGs (and possibly also NoVGs) can if they provide QUD-relevant information (Walter 2024). Walter (2024) has attributed this to the higher informativity of CVGs in comparison to OVGs.

Turning to pro-speech gestures next, it has been assumed that they make at-issue contributions (Schlenker 2021, Ebert 2024).

- (33) A: The window in my living room is _____. + RECTANGULAR
 B: That's not true! The window is round.

As for post-speech gestures, there is no consensus for their analysis. While Schlenker (2021) analyzes them as not-at-issue (patterning with appositives), Barnes & Ebert (2023a) and Ebert (2024) argue for a variable at-issue status of post-speech gestures: the more standalone a post-speech gesture is, the more likely it is to be at-issue. That is, if it is less integrated (e.g., due to a long pause before the gesture), it tends to be more at-issue.

- (34) A: Last year we went to Greece. _____ + HIKING
 B: That's not true! You spent all of your days at the beach.

Moreover, neither pro- nor post-speech gestures can be disregarded in ellipsis constructions (cf. Schlenker & Chemla 2018):

- (35) A: The window in my living room is _____. + RECTANGULAR
 B: In mine, too. #But it is actually round.
 (36) A: Last year we went to Greece. _____ + HIKING
 B: Two years ago, I did, too! #But I actually didn't go on any hikes there.

The examples on iconic co-speech, pro-speech, and post-speech gestures highlight the differences in their at-issue status: while co-speech gestures pattern with appositives in their projection behavior and are hence clearly not-at-issue by default, pro- and post-speech gestures behave more like asserted material and can be analyzed as at-issue material. Experimental evidence for the default at-issueness of pro-speech gestures comes from Fritzsche (to appear).

39.3.2.2 (Not-)at-issueness of emblematic gestures

Turning now to emblematic gestures, to our knowledge no in-depth research on their at-issue status has been carried out (but see Esipova 2019b, Ebert 2024 for some remarks

and discussion)³. Under the assumption that temporal alignment is the decisive factor for determining the at-issue status of speech-accompanying gestures, it is predicted that emblems should pattern with their iconic gesture counterparts. However, as Barnes & Ebert (2023b) note, there are other factors at play that affect the at-issue status of iconic enrichments in general. It is therefore also plausible to expect some differences between iconic and emblematic gestures in this respect, as emblematic gestures more frequently occur pro- and post-speech and less frequently co-speech and are also more lexicalized than iconic gestures (e.g., Kendon 1988).

Starting with the most frequent alignment patterns in which emblematic gestures occur, i.e., pro- and post-speech, consider the following examples, where A talks to B about their visit to the cinema and C, to whom A had talked earlier that day, overhears the conversation. Note that a third person C who has spoken to A before was included in the following examples because it would be awkward for speaker B to directly deny A's personal reaction or experience, such as liking a movie.

(37) A: I went to the cinema yesterday and _____. + THUMBS UP

C: That's not true! You told me this morning that you hated the movie.

(38) A: I went to the cinema yesterday. _____ + THUMBS UP

C: That's not true! You told me this morning that you hated the movie.

A direct objection to the gesture content appears felicitous, which suggests that emblematic gestures, like iconic ones, are default at-issue when they appear as pro- or post-speech gestures. The pro-speech use of an emblematic gesture further does not seem to project out of negation and other semantic operators either, as is illustrated in (39).⁴

(39) It is not the case that I found the movie I saw yesterday _____. I actually hated it. + THUMBS UP

To the extent that the first utterance of (39) is felicitous, the continuation seems licensed. And we can conclude that emblematic gestures make at-issue contributions if they occur pro- or post-speech.

Emblematic gestures can also occur co-speech. Ebert (2024) discusses a co-speech example of the emblematic THUMBS DOWN-gesture and concludes that they are interpreted not at-issue by default. However, judgments are not as clear-cut in these cases, it seems. Consider a variant of (37) where the THUMBS UP-gesture occurs co-speech. Imagine again that A talks to B about their visit to the cinema and C, who spoke to A earlier that day, overhears their conversation:

3 Schlenker (2018) discusses the different behavior of co- vs. post-speech facial expressions, which, although less conventionalized than emblems, are also emotionally loaded and evaluative and hence also good candidates for a comparison with expressives.

4 Note that the projection test does not work for post-speech gestures in general because the negation cannot target something that is outside the sentence. We therefore do not use it as a diagnostic for the at-issue status in the post-speech cases.

- (40) A: I went to the cinema yesterday. + THUMBS UP
 C: ?That's not true! You told me earlier that day that you didn't like the movie.

Intuitively, the response of C seems less degraded than the direct objections in the iconic co-speech cases (examples (33) and (34)). But looking at ellipsis constructions, things point again into the direction of a not-at-issue analysis of emblematic co-speech gestures:

- (41) A: I went to the cinema yesterday. + THUMBS UP
 B: Last week, I went, too! But I didn't like the movie.

Here, B's answer seems totally fine, suggesting that it makes a not-at-issue contribution. It seems that emblematic gestures pattern very much like iconic gestures, with the possibility that they are sometimes perceived as somewhat more at-issue in the co-speech case than iconic gestures are.

Finally, the projection behavior of emblematic gestures, as discussed in more detail by Esipova (2019b), is worth some discussion. In general, Esipova (2019a) presents a take on gesture semantics where the projection behavior of all expressions depends on the way these expressions enter the composition. Esipova (2019b) assumes a modality-blind syntax, thus allowing for speech-accompanying gestures to enter the compositional derivation in the same way as words do. This sets her approach apart from the ones proposed by Ebert, Ebert & Hörnig (2020) and Schlenker (2018), who both assume that the way in which speech-accompanying gestures enter the compositional derivation is fixed, i.e., gestures project uniformly in case they are co-speech and thus not-at-issue. Interestingly, Esipova notes different projection patterns for different types of emblematic gestures:

- (42) If you bring a semanticist to my talk, I'll likely fight with them. + CRAZY
 → If you bring a semanticist to my talk, I'll likely fight with them.
 → All semanticists are crazy. (Esipova 2019b: 557)

The CRAZY-gesture is an emblematic gesture indicating the speaker's opinion of someone or something, namely that the respective person or the state of affairs talked about is judged as crazy, realized, for example, by spinning the index finger in circles around one side of the forehead. According to Esipova (2019b), this emblematic gesture projects like a non-subjective modifier and seems to give rise to universal presupposition projection. Important for our purposes here is that the information provided by the gesture that (according to the speaker) all semanticists are crazy has to be contributed in the not-at-issue dimension in order to project in the observed way (cf. Tonhauser, Beaver & Degen 2018).

An example of an emblematic gesture that projects like a supplement and makes a not-at-issue contribution is shown in (43a). A paraphrase for the resulting meaning is given in (43b).

- (43) a. If a friend of mine wins the race, I'll buy them a drink. + FINGERS CROSSED
 b. If a friend of mine, {hopefully, fingers crossed}, wins the race, I'll buy them a drink. (Esipova 2019b: 557)

The gesture's contribution is paraphrased best as an appositive, i.e., supplement. Hence, it also projects like one.

On the other hand, there are other types of emblematic gestures that seem to behave like subsecutive modifiers and contribute their meaning at-issue.

- (44) a. Kim is bringing her friend to the party. + AIR QUOTES
 b. Kim is bringing her so-called friend to the party.

(Esipova 2019b: 557)

Interestingly, the AIR QUOTES-gesture makes an at-issue contribution. A not-at-issue contribution would lead to infelicity as the utterance would have to mean something along the lines that Kim is bringing her friend to the party and this friend is not an actual friend, which is contradictory.

Thus, the at-issue status of emblematic co-speech gestures is arguably less clear than the at-issue status of iconic co-speech gestures. Some appear to make at-issue contributions by default and thus do not project. Others, by contrast, show projective behavior and thus make default not-at-issue contributions. We will address this issue further below when discussing the expressive potential of different kinds of gestures.

39.3.2.3 Comparison between iconic gestures and emblems

We have seen so far that there is a divide between iconic pro- and post-speech gestures on the one hand and iconic co-speech gestures on the other concerning their at-issue status. While the former make default at-issue contributions, the latter alignment pattern makes a default not-at-issue contribution. This divide – as has been pointed out above – is similar, but not as clear-cut for emblematic gestures. While emblematic gestures make at-issue contributions when they occur pro- or post-speech, they at least seem to be somewhat more at-issue than their iconic counterparts in the co-speech cases. This has been illustrated by the observation that they seem to be (at least marginally) directly deniable, a property they share with at-issue content. In addition, according to Esipova (2019b), different projection patterns have been attested for different emblems, suggesting that not all emblematic gestures pattern alike. The question now is where these differences stem from and why emblems behave differently from iconic gestures. We will argue that this is due to their higher degree of conventionalization or, in other terms, lexicalization. Furthermore, the fact that they can express entire speech acts – in contrast to iconic gestures – might be the reason for their higher likelihood to occur pro- or post-speech.

In a first step, we will compare the different types of iconic gestures with each other. In general, and in contrast to emblematic gestures, iconic gestures have been argued to not be conventionalized (Kendon 1988, McNeill 1992, Kendon 2004). However, there is work suggesting that also within the group of iconic gestures there seem to be prototypical gestures for certain concepts. That is, certain concepts are gestured in very similar ways (for discussion, see Ortega & Özyürek 2020), which suggests that these gestures have been subject to some kind of conventionalization process. Consider the example in (45):

- (45) Peter waved at Mary. + WAVING



FIGURE 39.2 – Prototypical gesture for waving (Ortega & Özyürek 2020)

The prototypical WAVING gesture identified by Ortega & Özyürek (2020) in their study is shown in Figure 39.2. In a rating study, many speakers judged this gesture to be highly transparent – meaning they consistently recognized it as characteristic or prototypical of a waving event. Interestingly, many of these prototypical gestures describe an event and are therefore classified as viewpoint gestures. Furthermore, among these viewpoint gestures, prototypical CVGs were more frequently observed than OVGs. Walter, Ebert & Hinterwimmer (2024) propose an analysis of prototypical CVGs, arguing that these gestures are largely conventionalized. According to their account, only when a prototypical gesture is modified is it considered purely iconic. Therefore, prototypicality and conventionalization are closely intertwined in their framework. In contrast, fewer examples of prototypical gestures can be observed for gestures that do not encode viewpoint (but see Ortega & Özyürek 2020 for some examples of prototypical NoVGs). For instance, a ROUND gesture, as in (4), is not prototypical in the sense of depicting a round window. Rather, it seems more plausible that, without a co-occurring speech signal, this gesture merely denotes roundness or round objects in general. Thus, NoVGs appear to be lexically more underspecified than viewpoint gestures (henceforth, VGs). These observations lead to the following conventionalization scale for iconic gestures (decreasing conventionalization from left to right, > reads as “are more conventionalized than”):

(46) **Conventionalization scale for iconic gestures**

CVGs > OVGs > NoVGs

Note that this is also partly reflected in the at-issue status different types of iconic gestures have: CVGs have been argued to be more at-issue than OVGs and NoVGs if they provide QUD-relevant information (Walter 2024).

Turning to a comparison between emblematic and iconic gestures next, we follow Kendon (1988) in assuming that emblematic gestures are fully conventionalized and are thus the left-most item on the conventionalization scale:

(47) **Conventionalization scale for iconic and emblematic gestures**

Emblems > CVGs > OVG > NoVGs

Under the assumption that a higher degree of conventionalization results in – or, is due to – a higher degree of lexicalization of a gesture, this predicts that emblems have the highest potential to occur pro-speech, followed by CVGs, then OVGs, and finally NoVGs. This seems to be borne out:

- (48) A: How did you like the movie?
B: THUMBS UP

Here, the emblematic gesture THUMBS UP is a felicitous and sufficient answer of B to A's question. It can be paraphrased as *I liked it*, lending further support to the assumption that emblematic gestures can express entire speech acts.

It is also possible, but less natural, to answer with a CVG or an OVG although using an OVG in (49) is intuitively more awkward than using a CVG:

- (49) A: What did you do on Saturday?
B: CVG/OVG HIKING

Finally, the use of a pro-speech NoVG seems to be the most degraded in standalone cases:

- (50) A: What's the shape of the window in the living room? / What kind of window is in the living room?
B: #?ROUND

Thus, it seems that the more conventionalized a gesture, the better it can be used as a standalone pro-speech gesture. This is predicted if fully conventionalized gestures, i.e., emblems, are analyzed as expressing entire speech acts. This way, they do not depend on a co-occurring speech signal at all, whereas rather unconventionalized gestures (NoVGs) denoting an object or an event depend strongly on a co-occurring speech signal. Our intuition for CVGs and OVGs are that the former can be used more readily to express entire speech acts than the latter. This might relate to the data presented in Ortega & Özyürek (2020) where they found more prototypical – and consequently conventionalized – CVGs than OVGs. This higher rate of conventionalized CVGs makes it plausible to assume that they behave more like words than OVGs do. Therefore, it is probable that CVGs can also be used more readily to replace speech or express entire speech acts. We will argue in Section 39.4 that the conventionalization scale mirrors the extent to which the gestures discussed in the present work are expressive.

39.4 DETECTING EXPRESSIVITY IN GESTURE

.....

Expressive content has been proposed to be generally not-at-issue in the way detailed above. It functions as an operator that changes the context (Kaplan 1989) in specific ways. Potts (2007) discusses six criteria to identify expressive content: (1) independence, (2) nondisplaceability, (3) perspective dependence, (4) descriptive ineffability, (5) immediacy, and (6) repeatability (↪ *Expressivity: an introduction* by DANIEL GUTZMANN AND

KATHARINA TURGAY, Chapter 1 of this volume). In this section, we will describe these criteria, critically reflect on their suitability to characterize expressive content by taking into account more recent research, and discuss how they are met by the different types of gestures.

Furthermore, we want to suggest that a gesture's potential to stand alone and for expressing a speech act of its own also reflects its expressivity potential: the better a gesture can be used standalone, the higher is its expressive potential. Based on the diagnostics for expressive content, we will now investigate this hypothesis in more detail.

If the degree of conventionalization and the expressive potential pattern alike, we expect the same ordering on an expressivity scale as for the conventionalization scale stated in ??, repeated here for convenience:

(51) **Conventionalization scale for iconic and emblematic gestures**

Emblems > CVGs > OVG > NoVGs

To investigate this, we will examine which of the criteria to diagnose expressive content as defined by Potts (2007) are fulfilled by the three types of iconic gestures – CVGs, OVGs, and NoVGs – introduced in Section 39.2 and do the same for emblematic gestures.

39.4.1 Independence

Based on earlier work (Potts 2005), Potts (2007) argues that expressive content is independent of the rest of the speech signal in that it contributes meaning in a different dimension, i.e., it is not-at-issue. Since in his system, descriptive (i.e., at-issue) content and expressive not-at-issue content cannot interact (but see AnderBois, Brasoveanu & Henderson 2015 for an account where the meaning contributions in the different dimensions can interact), the independence criterion follows from it: expressive content can be changed or left out entirely without affecting the truth conditions of the overall utterance (Kaplan 1999/2004). Consider (2) again, repeated as (52):

(52) That bastard Kresge is famous.

This sentence expresses two propositions: the descriptive at-issue proposition that Kresge is famous and the not-at-issue expressive proposition that Kresge is a bastard or bad in the speaker's opinion. As discussed above, direct denial is not possible with not-at-issue content and hence should not be possible for expressive content either. This is borne out.

(53) A: That bastard Kresge is famous.
 B₁: No, he's not that famous.
 B₂: #No, he's not a bastard.

While B₁ can directly dissent with the descriptive content of A's utterance in (53), the same is not possible for B₂ who tried to deny the expressive content of A's utterance. This suggests that descriptive and expressive content should not be combined into a single meaning unit according to Potts (2007).

Iconic gestures If independence essentially means that an expressive item contributes its meaning in a different dimension as asserted content does – the not-at-issue dimension – iconic gestures occurring co-speech fulfill this criterion, since they have been shown to be not-at-issue (cf. Section 39.3.2).

We also noted in Section 39.3.2 that as soon as iconic gestures are performed as post- or pro-speech gestures, they shift toward the at-issue dimension. However, we would like to emphasize here that this should not be seen as a counterargument against the independence criterion. The shift toward the at-issue dimension comes about only if the information of the iconic gesture is needed to derive a full proposition (pro-speech) or when the gesture is temporally independent of the speech signal (post-speech). Thus, this seeming non-independence is driven by independent factors and does at its core not relate to the criterion as discussed in Potts (2007). This can be further strengthened when looking at the following German example, where the expressive mixed item *Köter* intuitively receives an at-issue interpretation due to the contrastive focus marking:

- (54) *Einen Hund würde ich das nicht mehr nennen, das ist ein Köter.*
 A dog would I this not anymore call this is a cur
 ‘I wouldn’t call this a dog, this is a cur.’

Here, the speaker’s judgment could be challenged by a response along the lines of *No, it’s not* without yielding infelicity. Again, also this example merely cannot be seen as evidence against the independence property. Rather, it shows that there are several factors that can overwrite this property.

Emblematic gestures For emblematic gestures occurring co-speech, we have noted that their at-issue status and therefore their independence property is not entirely clear. Using the diagnostics for not-at-issue content defined in Section 39.3.1, it was shown that the THUMBS UP-gesture only passes some of the tests for not-at-issueness in the co-speech case (cf. (40) and (41)). As noted by Esipova (2019b), other emblematic gestures, such as the CRAZY-gesture (cf. (42)) and the FINGERS CROSSED-gesture (cf. (43)) seem to project and therefore make not-at-issue contributions. Example (44), by contrast, shows that the AIR QUOTES-gesture seems to make an at-issue contribution even in co-speech cases. Although a systematic investigation of the at-issue status of co-speech emblematic gestures has not been executed up to now and the data are partly contradictory, we still hope to have shown that emblematic co-speech gestures at least can be not-at-issue. In pro- and post-speech cases, however, emblematic gestures make default at-issue contributions which, as we argue, is, as with iconic gestures, either due to their temporal independence of the speech signal (post-speech) or due to the necessity to integrate their meaning into the sentence because there simply is no speech signal that the listener can resort to.

39.4.2 Nondisplaceability

The property of nondisplaceability relates to the observation that outside of quotation, expressives “cannot be used to report on past events, attitudes, or emotions, nor can they express mere possibilities, conjectures, or suppositions” (Potts 2007: 169, cf. also Cruse

1986). This means that an expressive seems to predicate directly over the utterance situation (see also McCready 2021), setting expressives apart from regular expressions, which in general have been claimed to be displaceable (Hockett 1960) and can be used to talk about objects that are not present in the current context as well as hypothetical situations.

(55) Two days ago, I spilled fucking red wine over my new pair of white jeans.

If an expressive like *fucking* were displaceable, a reading of (55) is predicted where the speaker was unhappy about the fact that they spilled red wine over their white jeans two days ago, but is not in an agitated state of mind anymore. However, such a reading does not exist. The expressive *fucking* can only be interpreted as expressing that the speaker is unhappy about something in the current utterance situation. The nondisplaceability criterion, as McCready (2021) notes, directly follows from the independence criterion: since expressive content does not interact with semantic operators, it has to be interpreted in the current context.

Still, this does not mean that expressive adjectives like *damn* or *fucking* always express a negative attitude of the speaker towards what the modified element expresses ($\leftrightarrow$ *Expressivity and adjectives* by FABIAN BROSS, Chapter 22 of this volume). Instead, expressive adjectives allow for what Gutzmann (2019) refers to as ‘argument extension’ or even ‘argument hopping’, which means that sometimes, the negative attitude of the speaker does not necessarily target the syntactically associated item, but the negative attitude appears to extend to the entire proposition and is then associated with the reported event or even ‘hop’ to another argument.

(56) (We can’t come to the movies.)
My sister has to mow the damn lawn. (Potts 2005: 7)

In example (56) it is not necessarily the case that the speaker has a negative opinion towards the lawn, but the negative affect is rather directed towards the fact that the sister has to mow the lawn, which makes it impossible to come to the movies.

Interestingly, it seems that in the following example argument extension to the situation is much harder:

(57) My damn sister has to mow the lawn.

While (56) allows for an interpretation where the speaker is only annoyed about the fact that her sister has to mow the lawn, such an interpretation is not possible in (57). Here, the negative attitude has to (also) hold with respect to the sister. The exact conditions under which argument extension and hopping are possible are still under debate ($\leftrightarrow$ *Expressivity and adjectives* by FABIAN BROSS, Chapter 22 of this volume, see also Frazier, Dillon & Clifton 2015, Gutzmann 2019 for proposals to deal with this problem) and we will not discuss these further. It will be relevant for our purposes to note, however, that there are cases like (56) that allow for argument extension to the reported situation much more readily than others (57).

Iconic gestures Iconic gestures in general do not seem to fulfill the property of nondisplaceability. For CVGs and OVGs, this has been illustrated in example (13) (repeated below) already.

(58) Last year we went to Greece. + HIKING

Here, the viewpoint gesture, no matter if it is performed as a CVG or an OVG, refers to a past event, thus illustrating that their meaning contribution does not report on the current utterance context. The same holds for NoVGs as is shown in (59):

(59) When I went for a walk in a park two weeks ago, I passed by a beautiful gate. + BOW-SHAPE

Also here, the gesture clearly does not depend on the utterance situation. Instead, it makes reference to a past event, that is the event of seeing a beautiful gate in the park two weeks ago which was bow-shaped.

The examples in (58) and (59) thus stand in sharp contrast to examples containing expressives such as in (55) because there, the expressive adjective *fucking* can only express a negative attitude of the speaker toward the current utterance situation, not the situation that is being reported on.

Emblematic gestures The criterion of nondisplaceability appears to hold for emblematic gestures, however.

(60) Two days ago I saw a movie. + THUMBS UP

(61) Last week, Peter brought his friend Jonah to the party. + AIR QUOTES

(62) At the conference last month, there were many semanticists. + CRAZY

It seems that, even if the positive attitude towards the movie can be interpreted as displaced to a past situation when the movie was watched, for (60) it also has to hold that the speaker still likes the movie in the current utterance situation. The utterance cannot be made without communicating that the speaker still thinks the movie is great. The same seems to hold for (61). The then so-called friend cannot have turned into an actual friend in the meantime. And also for (62), only a reading is available that refers to the utterance time, namely that the speaker (generally) thinks that semanticists are crazy.

The property of nondisplaceability holds for pro-speech gestures, as well, as evidenced by the following example (a repetition of (48)):

(63) A: How did you like the movie?
B: THUMBS UP

Here, the gesture does not seem to report on a past event only. Instead, it seems to receive a nondisplaceable interpretation because by performing the gesture the speaker indicates that they are in an emotionally highlighted state due to the movie even in the current context.

As we have pointed out for expressive adjectives like *damn* or *fucking* above, for emblematic gestures as well, the negative or positive attitude that is transmitted via these expressions does not always have to target the associated item. In the case of an emblematic gesture like the THUMBS UP-gesture or the CRAZY-gesture, the positive or negative attitude does not always hold towards the speech expression that the emblem aligns with, but also seems to allow for some sort of argument extension or what could be dubbed ‘*associate extension*’. Consider variants of examples (56) and (57), where the expressive is substituted by the CRAZY-gesture.

- (64) (We can’t come to the movies.)
My sister has to mow the lawn. + CRAZY
- (65) My sister has to mow the lawn. + CRAZY

Like with expressive adjectives, it seems to make a difference in interpretation whether the CRAZY-gesture accompanies *lawn* or *sister*. To express annoyance about the fact that the sister has to mow the lawn (and the resulting fact that one cannot come to the movies), it would be far more natural to temporally align the gesture with *lawn* than with *sister*. If aligned with *sister*, the only interpretation remaining seems that the speaker is annoyed about their sister. This parallel shows that the argument extension behavior is not tied to expressive adjectives or expressives in speech. If the meaning contribution of emblematic gestures works along the same lines, the principle of argument extension is subject to a far more general principle (↔ *Expressivity and emojis* by PATRICK G. GROSZ, Chapter 29 of this volume and see Kaiser & Grosz 2021, Kaiser 2024 for related observations about projection with emojis).

39.4.3 Perspective dependence

Expressives in general are dependent on a perspective in their interpretation, or, more concretely, almost invariably on the perspective of the speaker. So, if we consider, for example, (55) above, it is the speaker who is annoyed of having spilled wine over their jeans.

However, although this speaker dependence is the standard, exceptions to this general scheme where expressives do not have to depend on the speaker’s perspective have been discussed:

- (66) My father screamed that he would never allow me to marry that bastard Webster.
(Kratzer 1999: 6)

Here – as noted by Kratzer (1999) – the epithet *that bastard* is not ascribed to the speaker. Rather, it is most naturally interpreted as a negative attitude of the speaker’s father toward Webster. Still, the default perspective to interpret expressives from is the speaker’s. Other interpretations are possible, but marked, and need to be contextually licensed (Harris & Potts 2009).

Interestingly, the perspective dependence observed for expressive items differs from that of, for example, predicates of personal taste such as *fun* in an important respect: for

expressives, the perspective is with the speaker most of the time and it remains constant, while the perspective can be that of someone else for predicates of personal taste and it can vary within one context. This is illustrated in (67) and (68). To make the examples felicitous, it is required that the perspective, implemented as the contextual judge for predicates of personal taste (Lasersohn 2005), shifts from the attitude holder (Sue or Jill) toward the speaker, which is possible in (68), but not in (67), where the continuation in parentheses is infelicitous.

(67) Sue believes that that bastard Kresge should be fired. (#I believe he's a good guy.)
(Potts 2007: 175)

(68) Jill believes the roller coaster was fun. I think it wasn't.

Thus, expressives more strongly depend on a single perspective than predicates of personal taste do.

Iconic gestures Although CVGs and OVGs are perspective-dependent per definition while NoVGs are not, it is easily shown that they behave very differently from spoken-language expressives, which are perspective-dependent, but almost always hinge on the speaker's perspective. CVGs and OVGs encode a viewpoint, but this need not be the speaker's. Rather, it is somewhat underspecified whose viewpoint is encoded in a viewpoint gesture. This seems to depend on the co-occurring speech signal. While perspective dependence for expressive content is defined as almost invariably being dependent on the speaker's perspective, the notion of viewpoint in gesture is defined "as the subject's perspective on an event or scene" (Parrill 2010: 653, cf. also Chafe 1976, DeLancey 1981). Hence, while the perspective dependence observed for expressives seems to be a phenomenon that has to do with their lexical semantics, speakers have a choice which viewpoint to encode when performing an iconic gesture: they can decide whether they want to adopt an internal perspective and thus perform a CVG or whether they want to adopt an external perspective and consequently perform an OVG. Thus, viewpoint choice observed for iconic gestures is not something that is comparable to the lexical encoding of speaker dependence observed for expressives. Viewpoint choice is guided by different factors which cannot be discussed here (see McNeill 1992, Parrill 2010). It thus seems that iconic gestures are not perspective-dependent in the sense defined for expressives in Potts (2007). Gesture viewpoint is rather flexible and not as tightly bound to the speaker. In this respect, gesture viewpoint patterns more with predicates of personal taste, where perspective allocation and perspective shift is more flexible than for expressives.

Emblematic gestures Emblematic gestures, in contrast, pattern with expressives in their perspective dependence in the sense that they are normally tied to the speaker. The example in (63) nicely illustrates this. The THUMBS UP-gesture must be interpreted as expressing a positive attitude toward the film of the speaker. The same holds for (60). The AIR QUOTES-gesture in (61) can only be interpreted as reflecting the speaker's opinion on the friendship status of Peter and Jonah. An interpretation from Peter's perspective in this example seems to be impossible. Finally, the modification of (62) as stated in (69) most plausibly reflects the speaker's opinion of semanticists, not Sarah's.

(69) At the conference last month, Sarah saw many semanticists. + CRAZY

Although it might be possible to shift the gesture's interpretation away from the speaker toward Sarah, it still holds that without further context, emblematic gestures are anchored to the speaker (see [Harris & Potts 2009](#) for experimental evidence that in general, expressives can shift in some contexts).

39.4.4 Descriptive ineffability

This term relates to the observation that speakers are unable to describe an expressive's meaning in descriptive terms – that is, without resorting to other expressive meaning ([Potts & Roeper 2006](#), [Potts 2007](#)). When speakers are forced to give definitions of expressives, the best they can normally come up with are contexts where one might felicitously use the expressive. In other words, they formulate use conditions. This observation led [Potts \(2007\)](#) to propose that expressive content is non-propositional. Instead, all the utterance of an expressive does is to introduce an expressive index (cf. also [Potts & Kawahara 2004](#)), that is, a triple consisting of two individuals and an interval. This interval ranges from -1 to 1 and encodes the orientation of the expressive (-1 = negative, 0 = neutral, 1 = positive) as well as the expressive relationship between the two individuals: the smaller the interval, the stronger the (positive or negative) expressive relationship. [Potts \(2007\)](#) additionally argues that the utterance of an expressive always shrinks the interval, that is, the expressive relationship between the two individuals becomes stronger with each utterance of an expressive item.

Note that the property of descriptive ineffability to diagnose expressive content is, to some extent at least, controversial. While it is intuitively plausible that paraphrasing expressive content is difficult without resorting to other expressive content, it has been noted that most non-expressive expressions are subject to the same constraint ([Geurts 2007](#)): it often does not seem satisfactory to use other (descriptive) terms to paraphrase the content of a lexical item. Thus, this property is by no means sufficient to diagnose expressive content. Further criteria have to be fulfilled in order to classify a lexical item as expressive (see also [McCready 2021](#)).

Iconic gestures Iconic gestures in general pattern with expressives in terms of their descriptive ineffability. Consider the HIKING-CVG used in (58), for example. Depending on what additional information is encoded beside the hiking, it intuitively seems to be insufficient to just describe the gesture with descriptive terms, as some spatial information might be missing or not capturable at all in the description, no matter how detailed it may be. The same intuitively holds for OVGs and NoVGs. This, however, could also be due to the low degree of conventionalization of iconic gestures.

Emblematic gestures Emblematic gestures, too, share the property of being descriptively ineffable with iconic gestures and expressives. Intuitively, none of the emblematic gestures discussed so far seem to be paraphrasable by means of purely descriptive terms. Accordingly, it is not possible to give an adequate description of the CRAZY-gesture as

used in (62), for example. The same seems to hold for the THUMBS UP-gesture. An even more extreme case seems to be the MIDDLE FINGER-gesture because here, a strongly negative attitude of the speaker toward the addressee is expressed. Here, the most adequate paraphrase would be *Fuck you!*, but, as can be noted, another expressive term is needed for the paraphrase.

39.4.5 Immediacy

There is a tight connection between expressives and speech acts. It has been noted that honorifics resemble performative speech acts in that they “establish a relationship with the interlocutor” (Tsujimura 1978: 223) just like promises, for example. Potts (2007) proposes to extend this to expressive items in general. This means that the sole act of uttering an expressive suffices to perform a certain act and to commit oneself to all that comes with this act. To illustrate this, consider first the utterance in (70):

(70) I promise that I will take the dog on a walk this afternoon.

By simply uttering (70), the speaker commits themselves to taking the dog on a walk later on the day the utterance takes place. There is a similar kind of immediate commitment that comes with expressives:

(71) That bastard Jonah didn’t do the dishes last week. #Today, however, he isn’t a bastard because he did them today.

Here, the speaker commits themselves to having a negative attitude toward Jonah by virtue of uttering the epithet *that bastard* in the first sentence. Therefore, the second sentence is an infelicitous continuation in (71) as the speaker here tries to retract their earlier expressed negative attitude toward Jonah.

Some very offensive expressives like ethnic slurs can even be characterized as highly ‘toxic’ (e.g., Nunberg 2013): in the second they are uttered they spread their poison and act as offensive, even if they are structurally deeply embedded or simply quoted from other people, thus evidencing their immediate force.

Iconic gestures Iconic gestures do not appear to fulfill the criterion of immediacy. When embedded in a hypothetical setting, they do not apply to the current speech situation and do not commit the speaker to any immediate consequences that would be expressed by the gesture content.

(72) If the window in Paul’s living room is round, this would be very unusual. + ROUND

(73) If Peter went hiking this summer, he will be in a good mood. + HIKING

Both examples involve iconic gestures, a NoVG in (72) and a CVG or OVG in (73), but the speaker is not committed to the view that the window in Paul’s living room is actually round or that there was a hiking event Paul attended this summer, respectively.

Emblematic gestures In contrast, the immediacy criterion seems to be fulfilled by emblematic gestures as can be evidenced by reconsidering example (60), repeated below with an infelicitous continuation.

- (74) I saw a movie last week. #This week, I don't like it anymore because it has become too mainstream. + THUMBS UP

Here, the attitude of the speaker is expressed by virtue of the gesture being produced. As illustrated by the infelicity of the continuation, this attitude cannot be altered.

Also alongside very offensive expressives in speech, certain highly offensive gestures can be characterized as 'toxic': they cannot be performed without immediately acting as an insult, independent of whether they are presented as quotes from somebody else or the speaker aims at distancing from them in some other way.⁵

39.4.6 Repeatability

The final criterion for expressive content proposed in Potts (2007) sets it apart from regular descriptive content most drastically. While repeating a descriptive item yields an effect of redundancy, the reverse holds for expressive content: repeating it within a sentence gives rise to an effect of strengthening of the expressive meaning. The latter is illustrated by (75).

- (75) a. Fuck, I forgot my wallet in the office again.
b. Fuck, I forgot my fucking wallet in the office again.
c. Fuck, I forgot my fucking wallet in the fucking office again.

Here, each repetition of the expressive item *fuck* results in a strengthened meaning of the speaker's anger about the fact that they forgot their wallet in the office again. Replacing the expressive by descriptive content as in (75c), however, results in redundancy and awkwardness:

- (76) #I'm angry! I forgot my wallet again. I'm angry! I left it in the office. I'm angry!

Potts (2007) takes this as an additional argument in favor of his proposal that expressive content predicates something on the utterance situation, or – in other words – each repetition of an expressive changes the expressive index in a way that it further narrows the interval associated with it.

According to Gutzmann (2013) and McCready (2021), repeatability as a characteristic feature of expressives is controversial. While in general, a lot of expressive items seem to fulfill this criterion, others do not permit repetitions at all. Expressive adjectives like *fucking* or *damn* do allow for repetition. However, words like *oops* are at least not strength-

5 Note that using certain emblems is even subject to legal penalties, as is evidenced by the existence of diverse German judicial decisions judging emblems like to tap one's forehead or to give somebody the finger as legal insult that can be fined, e.g. ArbG Dortmund, resolution of September 8, 2006, Az. 8 BV 110/06. This is, interestingly, also something that is shared with expressives: → *Expressivity and the law* by ELYSE METHVEN, Chapter 40 of this volume.

ened by repeating them and repeating them seems also a bit redundant (Gutzmann 2013: 47).

- (77) a. #Oops! I forgot my keys. Oops! They are in the car. Oops!
 b. #Ouch! I've hit my thumb. Ouch! It was the hammer. Ouch!

Greetings such as *Good afternoon* or *Hi* lead to the same redundancy as descriptive content would when repeating them, while other expressives, like some particles, cannot be repeated at all. Therefore, we need to handle this criterion with some caution.

Iconic gestures Iconic gestures cannot be repeated for a strengthening or emphatic effect. If an iconic gesture is repeated, this repetition is usually meaningful and interpreted as such.

- (78) In Paul's living room there is a window. + 2 × ROUND

If the speaker repeats the ROUND gesture, this will be interpreted as to the effect that the window talked about consists of two round parts, or it would lead to infelicity since the speaker talks about one window, but gestures two. Unlike in speech, repetition does not lead to redundancy here, but rather to infelicity or a different interpretation. Clearly, it does not have an emphatic effect as has been reported for the repetition of expressive elements.

Emblematic gestures Emblematic gestures also seem to pattern with expressives in terms of repeatability. Repeating offensive gestures such as the MIDDLE FINGER- or CRAZY-gesture or positively connotated gestures like the THUMBS UP-gesture leads to the same effect of emphasis as has been discussed for spoken language expressives.

- (79) I really hate this idiot. + 5 × MIDDLE FINGER (each aligned with one word)

39.4.7 Emblems as gestural expressives

Except for the independence criterion, for which we have discussed some problematic cases, emblems clearly meet all the criteria of expressive items. Iconic gestures (CVGs, OVGs, and NoVGs), on the other hand, only meet this criterion and descriptive ineffability. The findings for emblematic and iconic gestures are summarized in Table 39.1.

As Geurts (2007) pointed out that the criterion of descriptive ineffability applies to most, also ordinary descriptive, expressions, meeting this criterion should not be taken as indicative of a classification of iconic gestures as expressives. Thus, it seems that emblematic gestures can be classified as expressive because they fulfill (at least to some considerable extent) all the criteria for expressive content as proposed by Potts (2007). Iconic gestures, in contrast, do not meet most of the criteria.

TABLE 39.1 – Expressive properties of emblems and iconic gestures

	Emblems	Iconic gestures
Independence	(✓)	✓
Nondisplaceability	✓	✗
Perspective dependence	✓	✗
Descriptive ineffability	✓	✓
Immediacy	✓	✗
Repeatability	✓	✗

39.5 CONCLUSION

.....

From what has been discussed in this contribution, we claim that expressivity is a phenomenon that is modality-independent and that we find in the spoken as well as in the visual modality. After all, emblematic gestures should be classified as expressives in the visual domain.

Iconic gestures cannot be classified as making an expressive contribution. As noted before, the ordering of the expressivity scale is the same as for the conventionalization scale as shown in (47). However, expressivity does not generally decrease. We therefore propose the following scale for expressivity in gesture (where > reads as “are more expressive than” and = reads as “are equally expressive as”):

(80) Emblems > CVGs = OVGs = NoVGs

The findings presented in this chapter should be taken with some caution, however. Potts (2007) exclusively defined the criteria of expressive content for spoken expressive content. To our knowledge, there is no previous research on expressivity in gesture. This is the first attempt to apply these criteria to identify expressivity in the visual domain.

ACKNOWLEDGMENTS

.....

We wish to express our sincere gratitude to the editors of this handbook, Daniel Gutzmann and Katharina Turgay, as well as to Lennart Fritzsche, for their valuable feedback on the work presented in this chapter.

.....

B I B L I O G R A P H Y

.....

- AnderBois, Scott, Adrian Brasoveanu & Robert Henderson. 2015. At-issue proposals and appositive impositions in discourse. *Journal of Semantics* 32(1). 93–138.
- Barnes, Kathryn & Cornelia Ebert. 2023a. Iconicity and gradient at-issueness: Insights and future avenues. Reply to replies. *Theoretical Linguistics* 49(3–4). 167–223.
- Barnes, Kathryn & Cornelia Ebert. 2023b. The information status of iconic enrichments: Modelling gradient at-issueness. *Theoretical Linguistics* 49(3–4). 167–223.
- Barnes, Kathryn, Cornelia Ebert, Robin Hörnig & Theresa Stender. 2022. The at-issue status of ideophones in German: An experimental approach. *Glossa: A Journal of General Linguistics* 7(1). 1–39.
- Beattie, Geoffrey & Heather Shovelton. 2002. An experimental investigation of some properties of individual iconic gestures that mediate their communicative power. *British Journal of Psychology* 93(2). 179–192.
- Beaver, David I., Craige Roberts, Mandy Simons & Judith Tonhauser. 2017. Questions under discussion: Where information structure meets projective content. *Annual Review of Linguistics* 3(1). 265–284.
- Brown, Amanda. 2008. Gesture viewpoint in Japanese and English. *Gesture* 8(2). 256–276.
- Chafe, Wallace L. 1976. Givenness, contrastiveness, definiteness, subjects, topics, and point of view. In Charles N. Li & Sandra A. Thompson (eds.), *Subject and Topic*, 27–55. New York: Academic Press.
- Cruse, D. Alan. 1986. *Lexical Semantics*. Cambridge: Cambridge University Press.
- DeLancey, Scott. 1981. An interpretation of split ergativity and related patterns. *Language* 57(3). 626–657.
- Ebert, Christian & Cornelia Ebert. 2014. *Gestures, demonstratives, and the attributive/referential distinction*. Talk given at Semantics and Philosophy in Europe 7, June 2014. ZAS Berlin.
- Ebert, Christian, Cornelia Ebert & Robin Hörnig. 2020. Demonstratives as dimension shifters. *Proceedings of Sinn und Bedeutung* 24. 161–178.
- Ebert, Cornelia. 2024. Semantics of gesture. *Annual Review of Linguistics* 10(1). 169–189.

- Ebert, Cornelia, Stefan Evert & Katharina Wilmes. 2011. Focus marking via gestures. *Proceedings of Sinn und Bedeutung* 15. 193–208.
- Ebert, Cornelia, Andreas Konietzko & Thomas Weskott. 2021. Recovering gestured and spoken material in VP ellipsis and pro-forms. *Proceedings of Sinn und Bedeutung* 28. 256–266.
- Ebert, Cornelia, Giovanna Pirillo & Sebastian Walter. 2022. The role of gesture-speech alignment for gesture interpretation. *Proceedings of Linguistic Evidence 2020: Linguistic Theory Enriched by Experimental Data*. 65–77.
- Emmorey, Karen. 1999. Do signers gesture. In Lynn S. Messing & Ruth Campbell (eds.), *Gesture, speech, and sign*, 133–159. Oxford: Oxford University Press.
- Esipova, Maria. 2019a. *Composition and Projection in Speech and Gesture*. New York University dissertation.
- Esipova, Maria. 2019b. Towards a uniform super-linguistic theory of projection. *Proceedings of the 22nd Amsterdam Colloquium*. 553–562.
- Farkas, Donka F. & Kim B. Bruce. 2010. On reacting to assertions and polar questions. *Journal of Semantics* 27(1). 81–118.
- von Fintel, Kai. 2004. Would you believe it? The king of France is back! Presuppositions and truth-value intuitions. In Marga Reimer & Anne Bezuidenhout (eds.), *Descriptions and Beyond*, 269–296. Oxford: Oxford University Press.
- Frazier, Lyn, Brian Dillon & Charles Clifton. 2015. A note on interpreting damn expressives: Transferring the blame. *Language and Cognition* 7(2). 291–304.
- Frazier, Lyn, Brian Dillon & Charles Clifton. 2018. Together they stand: Interpreting not-at-issue content. *Language and Speech* 61(2). 199–226.
- Fritzsche, Lennart. to appear. Do pro-speech gestures trigger presuppositions? *Proceedings of ConSOLE XXXII*.
- Geurts, Bart. 2007. Really fucking brilliant. *Theoretical Linguistics* 33(2). 209–214.
- Goldin-Meadow, Susan. 2005. *Hearing Gesture: How our Hands Help us Think*. Cambridge, MA: Harvard University Press.
- Goldin-Meadow, Susan & Diane Brentari. 2017. Gesture, sign, and language: The coming of age of sign language and gesture studies. *Behavioral and Brain Sciences* 40. E46.
- Gutzmann, Daniel. 2012. *Use-Conditional Meaning*. University of Frankfurt dissertation.
- Gutzmann, Daniel. 2013. Expressives and beyond: An introduction to varieties of use-conditional meaning. In Daniel Gutzmann & Hans-Martin Gärtner (eds.), *Beyond Expressives: Exploration in Use-Conditional Meaning*, 1–58. Leiden: Brill.
- Gutzmann, Daniel. 2019. *The Grammar of Expressivity*. Oxford: Oxford University Press.
- Harris, Jesse A. & Christopher Potts. 2009. Perspective-shifting with appositives and expressives. *Linguistics and Philosophy* 32(6). 523–552.
- Hockett, Charles F. 1960. The origin of speech. *Scientific American* 203(3). 88–97.
- Ippolito, Michela. 2021. The contribution of gestures to the semantics of non-canonical questions. *Journal of Semantics* 38(3). 363–392.
- Kaiser, Elsi. 2024. On the relation between expressive meaning and information structure: Exploring focus-marking with emoji. *Proceedings of Sinn und Bedeutung* 28.

- Kaiser, Elsi & Patrick Grosz. 2021. Anaphoricity in emoji: An experimental investigation of face and non-face emoji. *Proceedings of the Linguistic Society of America* 6. 1009–1023.
- Kaplan, David. 1989. Demonstratives: An essay on the semantics, logic, metaphysics, and epistemology of demonstratives and other indexicals. In Joseph Almog, John Perry & Howard Wettstein (eds.), *Themes from Kaplan*, 481–563. Oxford: Oxford University Press.
- Kaplan, David. 1999/2004. *The meaning of ouch and oops: Explorations in the theory of meaning as use*. 2004 version. Ms. University of California, Los Angeles.
- Kendon, Adam. 1988. How gestures can become like words. In Fernando Poyatos (ed.), *Cross-Cultural Perspectives in Nonverbal Communication*. New York: C. J. Hogrefe.
- Kendon, Adam. 2004. *Gesture: Visible Action as Utterance*. Cambridge: Cambridge University Press.
- Koev, Todor. 2018. Notions of at-issueness. *Language and Linguistics Compass* 12(12). e12306.
- Kratzer, Angelika. 1999. *Beyond ouch and oops: How descriptive and expressive meaning interact*. Talk given at the Cornell Conference on Theories of Context Dependency. March 26, 1999. Ithaca, NY: Cornell University. <http://semanticsarchive.net/Archive/WEwNGUyO/>.
- Lascarides, Alex & Matthew Stone. 2009. A formal semantic analysis of gesture. *Journal of Semantics* 26.4. 393–449.
- Lasersohn, Peter. 2005. Context dependence, disagreement, and predicates of personal taste. *Linguistics and Philosophy* 28(6). 643–686.
- Loehr, Daniel P. 2004. *Gesture and Intonation*. Georgetown University, Washington, DC dissertation.
- McCawley, James D. 1998. *The Syntactic Phenomena of English*. Chicago: University of Chicago.
- McCready, Elin. 2021. Expressives. In Daniel Gutzmann, Lisa Matthewson, Cécile Meier, Hotze Rullmann & Thomas Ede Zimmermann (eds.), *The Wiley Blackwell Companion to Semantics*, 893–921. Oxford: Wiley-Blackwell.
- McNeill, David. 1992. *Hand and Mind: What Gestures Reveal about Thought*. Chicago: University of Chicago Press.
- McNeill, David. 2005. *Gesture and Thought*. Chicago: University of Chicago Press.
- McNeill, David. 2013. Gesture as a window onto mind and brain, and the relationship to linguistic relativity and ontogenesis. In Cornelia Müller, Alan Cienki, Ellen Fricke, Silva H. Ladewig, David McNeill & Sedinha Teßendorf (eds.), *Body – Language – Communication* (HSK 38/1), 28–54. Berlin: de Gruyter.
- Nunberg, Geoffrey. 2013. *Slurs aren't special*. Ms. University of California, Berkeley.
- Ortega, Gerardo & Aslı Özyürek. 2020. Systematic mappings between semantic categories and types of iconic representations in the manual modality: A normed database of silent gesture. *Behavior Research Methods* 52(1). 51–67.
- Özyürek, Aslı, Sotaro Kita, Shanley Allen, Reyhan Furman & Amanda Brown. 2005. How does linguistic framing of events influence co-speech gestures? Insights from crosslinguistic variations and similarities. *Gesture* 5(1-2). 219–240.

- Parrill, Fey. 2010. Viewpoint in speech-gesture integration: Linguistic structure, discourse structure, and event structure. *Language and Cognitive Processes* 25(5). 650–668.
- Pearson, Hazel. 2010. A modification of the “Hey, Wait a Minute” test. *Snippets* 22. 7–8.
- Potts, Christopher. 2005. *The Logic of Conventional Implicature*. Oxford: Oxford University Press.
- Potts, Christopher. 2007. The expressive dimension. *Theoretical Linguistics* 33(2). 165–198.
- Potts, Christopher. 2012. Conventional implicature and expressive content. In Claudia Maienborn, Klaus von Stechow & Paul Portner (eds.), *Semantics* (HSK 33.3), 2516–2536. Berlin: de Gruyter.
- Potts, Christopher, Ash Asudeh, Seth Cable, Yurie Hara, et al. 2009. Expressives and identity conditions. *Linguistic Inquiry* 40(2). 356–366.
- Potts, Christopher & Shigeto Kawahara. 2004. Japanese honorifics as emotive definite descriptions. *Proceedings of SALT* 14. 235–254.
- Potts, Christopher & Tom Roeper. 2006. The narrowing acquisition path: From declarative to expressive small clauses. In Ljiljana Progovac, Kate Paesani, Eugenia Casielles-Suárez & Ellen Barton (eds.), *The Syntax of Nonsententials: Multi-Disciplinary Perspectives*, 183–201. Amsterdam: John Benjamins.
- Rett, Jessica. 2021. A comparison of expressives and miratives. In Andreas Trotzke & Xavier Villalba (eds.), *Expressive Meaning Across Linguistic Levels and Frameworks*, 191–215. Oxford: Oxford University Press.
- de Ruiter, Jan P. 1998. *Gesture and Speech Production*. University of Nijmegen dissertation.
- de Ruiter, Jan P. 2000. The production of gesture and speech. In David McNeill (ed.), *Language and Gesture*. Cambridge: Cambridge University Press.
- de Ruiter, Jan P. 2007. Postcards from the mind: The relationship between speech, imagistic gesture, and thought. *Gesture* 7(1). 21–38.
- Schlenker, Philippe. 2018. Gesture projection and cosuppositions. *Linguistics and Philosophy* 41. 295–365.
- Schlenker, Philippe. 2021. Iconic presuppositions. *Natural Language & Linguistic Theory* 39. 215–289.
- Schlenker, Philippe & Emmanuel Chemla. 2018. Gestural agreement. *Natural Language & Linguistic Theory* 36. 587–625.
- Shanon, Benny. 1976. On the two kinds of presuppositions in natural language. *Foundations of Language* 14(2). 247–249.
- Simons, Mandy, Judith Tonhauser, David Beaver & Craige Roberts. 2010. What projects and why. *Proceedings of SALT* 20. 309–327.
- Stec, Kashmiri. 2012. Meaningful shifts: A review of viewpoint markers in co-speech gesture and sign language. *Gesture* 12(3). 327–360.
- Steinbach, Markus, Marco Coniglio & Katharina Paul. 2023. Why artichokes and palms don’t grow on trees: The grammaticalization of question particles from co-speech gesture in sign language. In Natascha Pomino, Eva-Maria Remberger & Julia Zwink (eds.), *From formal linguistic theory to the art of historical editions: The multifaceted dimensions of romance linguistics*, 81–103. Göttingen: Vandenhoeck & Ruprecht.

- Syrett, Kristen & Todor Koev. 2015. Experimental evidence for the truth conditional contribution and shifting information status of appositives. *Journal of Semantics* 32(3). 525–577.
- Tonhauser, Judith. 2012. Diagnosing (not-)at-issue content. *Proceedings of Semantics of Under-represented Languages of the Americas (SULA)* 6. 239–254.
- Tonhauser, Judith, David I. Beaver & Judith Degen. 2018. How projective is projective content? Gradience in projectivity and at-issueness. *Journal of Semantics* 35(3). 495–542.
- Tsujimura, Toshiki. 1978. Keigo to hikeigo [Honorifics and anti-honorifics]. In Yasuo Kitahara (ed.), *Keigo: Ronshuu nihongo kenkyuu 9 [Honorifics: Papers on research in Japanese]*, 218–231. Tokyo: Yuuseido.
- Walter, Sebastian. 2024. The at-issue status of viewpoint gestures: Evidence for gradient at-issueness. *Proceedings of Sinn und Bedeutung* 28.
- Walter, Sebastian, Cornelia Ebert & Stefan Hinterwimmer. 2024. *Viewpoint matters: Prototypical vs. non-prototypical co-speech gestures in the VP domain*. Poster presented at *Sinn und Bedeutung* 29. Noto, Italy.